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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Powell: Fed hit with DOJ subpoena

Central bank chair says administration threatens indictment

By Christopher Rugaber
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — Federal Reserve Chair Jerome Powell said Sunday the Department of Justice has served the central bank with subpoenas and threatened it with a criminal indictment over his testimony this summer about the Fed's building renovations.

The move represents an unprecedented escalation in President Donald Trump's battle with the Fed, an independent agency he has repeatedly attacked for not cutting its key interest rate as quickly as Trump prefers. The subpoena relates to his testimony before the Senate Banking Committee in June, Powell said, regarding the Fed's \$2.5 billion renovation of two office buildings, a project that Trump criticized as excessive.

Powell on Sunday cast off what has up to this point been a restrained approach to Trump's criticisms and personal insults, which he has mostly ignored. Instead, Powell issued a video statement in which he characterized the threat of criminal charges as simple "pretexts" to undermine the Fed's independence on setting interest rates. "This is about whether the Fed will be able to continue to set interest rates based on evidence and economic conditions — or whether instead monetary policy will be directed by political pressure or intimidation," Powell said.

It's a sharp departure from the Fed's understated response to Trump this year. The central bank has attempted to placate the administration by dialing back some policies, such as efforts to consider the impact of climate change on the banking

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Work continues on the Bally's Chicago casino project at the former Freedom Center site in Chicago on Wednesday. ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

New casinos to alter gambling landscape

Bally's Chicago, Hollywood Aurora plan openings this year, joining several that opened in 2025 and more in the works

By Robert Channick
Chicago Tribune

As construction on the 34-story Bally's Chicago hotel steadily rises skyward over the Ohio feeder ramp, things are looking up for the region's casinos in 2026 amid a building boom that is reshaping the gambling landscape.

Chicago-area casinos are coming off a big year in 2025, as

three new facilities boosted revenue and brought millions of additional players to the tables and slot machines.

It may be a whole new game in 2026, with the \$1.7 billion Bally's Chicago casino complex and a new land-based Hollywood Casino Aurora set to open. Several other casinos are putting shovels in the ground along both sides of the Wisconsin border for future development projects.

The state's 17 casinos generated more than \$1.9 billion in adjusted gross receipts in 2025, a 15% year-over-year gain, while admissions were up nearly 20% to more than 15.5 million visitors, according to data published Friday by the Illinois Gaming Board.

New casinos at Wind Creek Chicago Southland, Hard Rock Rockford and a new land-based Hollywood Casino Joliet all contributed to robust gains in 2025, which also saw the opening of the first Illinois racino at the downstate Fairmount Park horse racing track in April.

The building boom was created by Illinois' sweeping 2019 gambling expansion bill, which

added everything from six new casinos and land-based gaming to sports betting.

Rivers Casino Des Plaines remained the state's busiest gambling palace last year with \$503 million in adjusted gross receipts and nearly 3 million visitors, but the new venues are rapidly gaining ground.

Wind Creek, a 70,000-square-foot casino and adjacent hotel in south suburban East Hazel Crest, completed its first full year as the second busiest casino in Illinois, generating nearly \$198 million in revenue and more than 2.1 million admissions in 2025.

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Hair stylist Jami Jastrom cuts Naoa Dogo's hair at the Regimen Barber Collective in Kenosha on Thursday. "I already can't afford Kenosha," Jastrom says. ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Hit hard by factory shutdowns, Kenosha aims to reinvent itself

But some residents worry as questions of affordability loom large

By Brian J. Rogal
Chicago Tribune

If an ambitious redevelopment plan takes hold, investment totaling hundreds of millions of dollars could soon pour into Kenosha,

potentially transforming its economy and skyline five years after the police shooting of Jacob Blake attracted worldwide attention to the small lakefront city in Wisconsin.

The city replaced a damaged strip mall with an affordably priced apartment complex soon after the 2020 civil unrest that followed the Blake shooting. But that was just one step in a decades-

long effort to revitalize what had been a Rust Belt city hit by factory shutdowns.

Kenosha breathed new life into once-empty manufacturing sites, recently breaking ground on high-end residential developments near the city's harbor, part of a new, walkable downtown meant to attract thousands of residents.

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Filmmakers documenting immigration crackdown in Chicago, Minneapolis

By Tess Kenny
Chicago Tribune

Hours after a woman was shot and killed by a federal immigration agent in Minnesota, 400 miles away in Chicago's Little Village, Andrew Freer moved through a crowd of community members huddled quietly around a mural of the Virgin Mary, a small video camera in hand.

Through the stillness, he weaved in and around the group. He didn't ask questions, didn't pause anywhere too long, just swept the scene, capturing footage for a story he'd help tell in due time.

Freer is part of a small band of filmmakers from across the Chicago area on a mission to protect constitutional rights

through on-the-ground, documentary-style videos as President Donald Trump's aggressive immigration crackdown pushes on — with its propensity, in experts' estimation, for needless safety risks and often an approach of acting first and justifying later.

"We are trying to be truth-tellers," Freer said.

The filmmakers, who call themselves Go Fourth Media, will be spending the better part of this week in Minneapolis, a trip they had already planned before Wednesday's shooting.

With their footage, they hope to confront misinformation and give viewers a personal sense of enforcement activity's impact, a goal only exacerbated by raids'

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INSIDE

Agent's experience spans decades

The ICE agent who shot and killed Renee Good on a south Minneapolis street served in a multitude of law enforcement roles during a two-decade career that included military service. **Nation & World**

How the Bears pulled it off again

The Bears made an 18-point comeback in their 31-27 win over the Packers on Saturday in the wild-card round of the playoffs. But the comeback started months before the game began. **Chicago Sports**

